UAE BUSINESS SETUP & INVESTOR/PARTNER RESIDENCE VISA GUIDE

Mainland and Free Zone Companies | Prepared by Qarib – Nov 02, 2026

Important scope and pricing note

This guide explains the typical process for incorporating a UAE company and then applying for an owner/investor/partner residence visa. A company licence is not itself a residence visa. Fees differ by emirate, activity, legal form, office/flexi-desk, number of visas, immigration file, medical examination, Emirates ID, insurance and whether the applicant is inside or outside the UAE. There is no single official price list covering every UAE free zone. Accordingly, this guide lists the principal free zones and provides verified published price examples where available; it does not invent a price where the authority does not publish a comparable fixed tariff. Obtain a written, itemised quote from the authority before paying.

This is general information, not legal, tax or immigration advice. Regulated activities, nationality/security checks and individual circumstances can change the requirements.

1. What does “business visa” mean?

In everyday use, “business visa” may mean either (a) a short-term business visit/entry permission, or (b) residence based on owning or partnering in a UAE company. This guide focuses on the common route: incorporate a company, obtain its trade licence, open/activate the immigration establishment file if required, then apply for an investor/partner residence permit. A Green Residence for investors/partners is a separate five-year route with specific eligibility conditions; it is not automatically granted just because a company is formed.

Dubai’s GDRFA publishes an investor/partner Green Residence route and states that the applicant submits a photo, passport copy valid for at least six months, partnership/investment contract and trade licence. Its published page lists AED 200 residence-permit fee plus Knowledge and Innovation Dirhams, an inside-country fee where applicable, delivery, and notes that total cost can vary. Eligibility conditions include a qualifying legal form and a minimum paid share of AED 1 million for that particular Green Residence route. Do not confuse this route with ordinary company-sponsored investor/partner residence options in other emirates.

2. Mainland vs free zone: choose the right jurisdiction

Topic	Mainland company	Free zone company
Regulator	Relevant emirate’s Department of Economic Development/economic department (e.g., Dubai DET, Abu Dhabi ADDED/TAMM).	The specific free zone authority.
Market access	Generally can conduct approved activities across the UAE, subject to activity-specific rules and permits.	Generally operates within the zone and internationally. Mainland sales/services may require a distributor, mainland branch, dual licence or other permit, depending on activity and emirate.
Ownership	100% foreign ownership is available for most activities, but strategic-impact and regulated activities may have exceptions/conditions.	Usually up to 100% foreign ownership; legal forms and permitted activities depend on the zone.
Premises	A compliant business address/lease is generally required; some instant/virtual or low-cost licence products have exceptions or special conditions.	Options may include flexi-desk, shared office, dedicated office, warehouse or land; requirements vary by package and activity.
Best fit	Businesses serving UAE customers directly, local retail/services, and activities needing mainland permissions.	International trade, consulting, digital/media/sector-specific activities, logistics, and businesses that fit the zone’s permitted activities.
Cost pattern	Licence/registration, trade name, approvals, lease/Ejari where applicable, establishment/immigration, visa and other fees.	Package/licence, registration, facility, establishment/immigration, visa allocation and each visa’s processing/medical/ID/insurance fees.

3. Mainland company and visa: step-by-step

1. **Define activity and legal form:** Select exact activity code(s), licence type (commercial, professional, industrial, tourism or other applicable category) and legal form. Check foreign ownership and whether the activity is regulated.
2. **Reserve trade name:** Apply through the relevant emirate authority. The name must meet naming rules and not conflict with an existing name or restricted terms.
3. **Apply for initial approval:** Submit owner/manager details and the requested activity. Initial approval means no objection to proceed; it is not permission to start operating.
4. **Obtain external approvals if needed:** Examples include health, education, food, transport, telecom, finance, recruitment, media or other regulated sectors.
5. **Secure premises:** Arrange a compliant office/shop/warehouse lease. Dubai leases commonly require Ejari registration; other emirates have their own tenancy rules. Confirm whether the chosen licence category permits a flexi-desk or virtual address.
6. **Prepare and sign incorporation documents:** Prepare the Memorandum of Association (MOA) or other constitutional documents, manager appointment and any local service agent agreement if applicable to the legal form/activity. Notarisation/attestation may be needed.
7. **Submit final licence application and pay:** Upload initial approval, MOA, lease, approvals and other requested documents; pay the authority's invoice and collect the trade licence.
8. **Open immigration file and apply for establishment card:** Where required, register the company with the relevant immigration authority and obtain/activate its establishment card/file. Labour registration may also be needed if hiring staff.
9. **Apply for investor/partner entry permit or change status:** The company or authorised service channel applies using the licence and shareholder/partner evidence. If the applicant is in the UAE, an in-country status change may add fees.
10. **Complete medical, biometrics and Emirates ID:** Follow the immigration authority's instructions. Medical fitness is generally required for adult residence applicants; biometrics/Emirates ID and health insurance requirements apply.
11. **Residence permit issuance and compliance:** Once approved, the residence permit is issued electronically/through the relevant channel. Keep the licence, establishment/immigration records, insurance and renewals current.

4. Free zone company and visa: step-by-step

12. **Match activity to zone:** Choose a zone that explicitly permits the activity and suits your customer base, office/storage needs, visa quota and budget.
13. **Select entity and shareholders:** Common forms include FZE (often one shareholder), FZCO/FZ-LLC (often multiple shareholders) and branch. Exact forms and shareholder limits vary by authority.
14. **Request an itemised quotation:** Ask for licence, registration, trade name, facility, establishment card/immigration file, visa allocation, each visa, medical, Emirates ID, insurance, e-channel/admin fees, deposits and renewal costs.
15. **Submit application and KYC:** Complete the authority's application, shareholder/manager details, passport/photo and business activity information. Corporate shareholders usually provide parent-company documents and attestations.
16. **Authority review and payment:** The authority checks the activity, names, KYC and supporting documents. Pay the invoice and sign incorporation/facility documents.
17. **Licence and company documents issued:** After approval, the authority issues the licence and incorporation documents. Government guidance says many free-zone licences are issued within about 14 working days after approval; straightforward packages may be faster, while complex cases take longer.
18. **Establishment/immigration file and visa allocation:** Complete the zone's immigration registration steps and confirm how many visas the package/facility supports. A licence advertised as "zero visa" or "one visa" must be checked carefully.
19. **Entry permit/status change, medical, ID and residence:** Apply for the relevant owner/partner residence route, complete medical/biometrics and insurance requirements, and wait for final issuance.
20. **Post-setup compliance:** Open a bank account (approval is separate and not guaranteed), register for UAE corporate tax where required, register for VAT when legally required, maintain accounting records and file beneficial-owner information.

5. Documents checklist

For individual shareholder(s)/manager

- Clear colour passport copy (normally passport validity of at least six months for visa applications).
- Recent passport-size photograph meeting UAE specifications.
- Current UAE visa/entry stamp or residence copy, if already in the UAE.
- Contact details, residential address, nationality and occupation details requested on KYC forms.
- Proof of address or bank reference/source-of-funds information if requested by the authority or bank.
- Business activity description, proposed trade names and ownership/share split.
- Specimen signature, KYC/UBO declarations and application forms required by the chosen authority.
- Existing Emirates ID, if applicable.
- Entry permit/status-change records and medical/health-insurance documents at the visa stage.

For mainland licence

- Trade name reservation and initial approval receipt.
- Completed licence application and activity selections.
- MOA/constitutional documents and manager appointment, as applicable.
- Lease/tenancy contract and Ejari or local equivalent where required.
- External authority approvals for regulated activities.
- Local service agent agreement if legally required for the selected structure/activity.
- Passport/identity documents for all shareholders and manager; corporate shareholder documents if applicable.

For free zone licence

- Free zone application, KYC form and specimen signature for each shareholder/signatory.
- Passport copies and photographs of shareholders, directors/managers and authorised signatories.
- UAE visa/entry page and Emirates ID copies where applicable.
- Detailed activity description and requested trade names.
- Proof of address or additional compliance documents if requested.
- Facility/lease agreement and signed zone rules/undertakings.
- For a corporate shareholder: certificate of incorporation, constitutional documents, board resolution, register of directors/shareholders, incumbency/good-standing certificate and ultimate beneficial owner details; notarisation, legalisation, translation or UAE attestation may be required.
- Branch applicants: parent company licence/incorporation documents, board resolution and parent-company authorisation.

At the visa stage

- Valid passport and compliant photograph.
- Trade licence and shareholder/partner proof (MOA, share certificate or investment contract, as requested).
- Establishment/immigration file details and visa allocation.
- Entry permit or in-country status-change application.
- Medical fitness result, Emirates ID application/biometrics and valid health insurance as applicable.

6. How many shareholders can one company have?

There is no single shareholder limit for every UAE company. It depends on the legal form, regulator and free zone. Common patterns are: a sole establishment/FZE may allow one shareholder; FZCO/FZ-LLC often allows two or more; a mainland LLC generally has 1–50 shareholders under the applicable company-law framework; a branch is not a separate shareholding company and belongs to its parent. Some zones offer different forms or their own caps. Confirm the chosen authority's current rule before filing, especially for corporate shareholders, multiple activities or regulated sectors.

7. How long does it take?

Stage	Typical planning range	What can delay it
Simple licence issuance	Same day to around 14 working days after complete submission/approval; not guaranteed.	Name/activity checks, KYC, missing papers, external approvals.
Mainland setup end-to-end	Often several working days to a few weeks for a straightforward case.	Lease/Ejari, MOA notarisation, regulated approvals, office fit-out.
Free zone setup end-to-end	Often a few days to about 2–3 weeks for a straightforward case.	Zone review, corporate shareholder attestations, facility selection.
Investor/partner residence after licence	Plan for additional days to a few weeks, depending on entry permit, status change, medical, biometrics and authority workload.	Applicant location, document issues, medical/insurance, security review.

Treat these as planning estimates, not service guarantees. The official UAE free-zone guidance says licences are commonly issued within 14 working days after approval; actual authority service levels differ.

8. Costs and published price examples

Important: compare like with like. A headline “starting from” package may exclude VAT, visa processing, immigration file, establishment card, medical, Emirates ID, insurance, office upgrade, activity approvals, bank costs and annual renewal. A company licence fee is not the total cost of obtaining residence.

Authority / price reference	Published example found	What it includes / caution	Official link
Creative City Free Zone, Fujairah	AED 3,999 Media Package; AED 9,999 Elite; AED 18,500 Elite+	Authority page advertises up to 10 shareholders and 10 activities; Elite lists 1 visa, Elite+ lists 2 visas (page wording also mentions up to 15 visas—confirm exact quota and inclusions in writing). Packages can change.	https://creativecity.gov.ae/company-set-up/
Dubai free zones (official Dubai investment portal)	Freelance packages from AED 5,000; office for four from AED 62,500	Portal gives broad indicative examples, not a like-for-like all-in company + residence visa quote. Its detailed zone cost page warns listed prices were correct as of September 2023 and may change.	https://www.investindubai.gov.ae/en/business-setup/free-zone-companies/free-zone-set-up-costs
Dubai Green Residence investor/partner route (GDRFA)	Residence-permit fee AED 200, plus listed charges	Knowledge Dirham AED 10, Innovation Dirham AED 10, in-country fee AED 500 where applicable, delivery AED 20; GDRFA notes total can vary. This is not the company licence cost. The Green Residence route has specific eligibility, including a minimum AED 1 million paid share under its published conditions.	https://gdrfad.gov.ae/en/services/f52024c6-b812-11ed-5210-4cd98f768936
All other free zones	No single comparable official fee	Each authority prices by activity, licence type, facility, visa quota, company form and promotions. Request a dated, itemised quotation from the relevant authority; do not rely solely on agent advertising.	See directory below

9. UAE free zone directory (principal authorities and zones)

The UAE has 40+ free zones/zone authorities, and the list changes as zones, clusters and registrars are reorganised. The following consolidated directory includes the principal zones identified by UAE Government and Ministry of Economy sources, plus sector-specific zones commonly referenced by official registrars. This is a practical directory, not a promise that every named zone is a separate legal registrar. Use the linked official UAE directory to verify the current authority and obtain its latest fee schedule.

Abu Dhabi

- **Abu Dhabi Global Market (ADGM) —** https://www.adgm.com/
- **Khalifa Economic Zones Abu Dhabi (KEZAD / formerly KIZAD) —** https://www.kezadgroup.com/
- **Masdar City Free Zone —** https://masdarcityfreezone.com/
- **Abu Dhabi Airports Free Zone (ADAFZ) —** https://www.adafz.ae/
- **twofour54 / Creative Media Authority —** https://www.twofour54.com/

Dubai

- **Dubai Multi Commodities Centre (DMCC) —** https://dmcc.ae/
- **Jebel Ali Free Zone (JAFZA) —** https://www.jafza.ae/
- **Dubai Airport Free Zone (DAFZ) —** https://www.dafz.ae/
- **Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC) —** https://www.difc.com/
- **Dubai South —** https://www.dubaisouth.ae/
- **Dubai Silicon Oasis (DSO) —** https://www.dso.ae/
- **Dubai Internet City —** https://www.dubaiinternetcity.com/
- **Dubai Media City —** https://www.dubaimediacity.com/
- **Dubai Production City —** https://www.dubaiproductioncity.com/
- **Dubai Studio City —** https://www.dubaistudiocity.com/
- **Dubai Outsource City —** https://www.dubaioutsourcecity.com/
- **Dubai Knowledge Park —** https://www.dubaiknowledgepark.com/
- **Dubai International Academic City —** https://www.diacedu.ae/
- **Dubai Science Park —** https://www.dubaisciencepark.com/
- **Dubai Design District (d3) —** https://dubaidesigndistrict.com/
- **Dubai CommerCity —** https://www.dubaicommercity.ae/
- **Dubai Healthcare City —** https://www.dhcc.ae/
- **Dubai Humanitarian —** https://www.dubaihumanitarian.ae/
- **Dubai Maritime City —** https://www.dubaimaritimecity.com/
- **Gold & Diamond Park —** https://www.goldanddiamondpark.com/
- **Meydan Free Zone —** https://www.meydanfz.ae/
- **Dubai World Trade Centre Authority (DWTC Free Zone) —** https://www.dwtc.com/
- **National Industries Park —** https://www.nip.ae/
- **Dubai Textile City —** https://www.jafza.ae/
- **Dubai Auto Zone (DAZ) —** https://www.jafza.ae/
- **Dubai Wholesale City —** https://www.dubaiwholesalecity.com/

Sharjah

- **Sharjah Airport International Free Zone (SAIF Zone) —** https://www.saif-zone.com/
- **Hamriyah Free Zone —** https://www.hfza.ae/
- **Sharjah Media City (Shams) —** https://www.shams.ae/
- **Sharjah Publishing City Free Zone —** https://www.spcfz.ae/
- **Sharjah Research, Technology and Innovation Park (SRTIP) —** https://srtip.ae/

Ajman

- **Ajman Free Zone —** https://www.afz.ae/
- **Ajman Media City Free Zone —** https://amcfz.ae/

Umm Al Quwain

- **Umm Al Quwain Free Trade Zone —** https://uaqftz.com/

Ras Al Khaimah

- **Ras Al Khaimah Economic Zone (RAKEZ) —** https://rakez.com/
- **RAK Maritime City —** https://www.rakmaritimecity.com/
- **Innovation City —** https://innovationcity.ae/

Fujairah

- **Fujairah Free Zone —** https://fujairahfreezone.com/
- **Creative City Free Zone —** https://creativecity.gov.ae/

Official government directory of free-zone authorities: https://u.ae/information-and-services/business/doing-business-in-free-zones/starting-a-business-in-a-free-zone

Ministry of Economy & Tourism company registrars directory: https://www.moet.gov.ae/en/company-registrars-in-free-zones

10. Tax, banking and post-incorporation reminders

- Corporate tax: registration and filing obligations depend on the company and activity. A free zone does not automatically mean all income is tax-free; the 0% rate applies only to qualifying income where all Qualifying Free Zone Person conditions are met. Non-qualifying income may be taxed under the applicable rules.
- VAT: mandatory registration generally applies when taxable supplies/imports exceed AED 375,000, subject to the applicable rules. Voluntary registration threshold and exceptions should be checked with the Federal Tax Authority.
- Beneficial ownership: maintain accurate ultimate beneficial owner/shareholder records and submit required information within the applicable deadline.
- Bank account: company formation does not guarantee bank account approval. Banks may ask for business plan, contracts/invoices, source-of-funds evidence, shareholder CVs, proof of address and expected transaction profile.
- Renewal: licences, facilities, immigration files, residence permits and insurance have separate renewal dates and fees. Budget annual renewals, not just initial formation.
- Mainland trade from a free zone: confirm the legal route before invoicing or supplying mainland customers. Requirements vary by emirate, activity and current rules.

11. Official sources and verification links

- **UAE Government — starting a business in a free zone:** https://u.ae/information-and-services/business/doing-business-in-free-zones/starting-a-business-in-a-free-zone
- **UAE Government — steps to start a business on the mainland:** https://u.ae/en/information-and-services/business/doing-business-on-the-mainland/steps-to-start-a-business-on-the-mainland
- **Dubai Government — business setup options:** https://www.dubai.ae/web/dubai.ae/investing/starting-a-business/business-set-up-options
- **Invest in Dubai — free zone setup costs (price caveat):** https://www.investindubai.gov.ae/en/business-setup/free-zone-companies/free-zone-set-up-costs
- **GDRFA Dubai — Green Residence for investor/partner:** https://gdrfad.gov.ae/en/services/f52024c6-b812-11ed-5210-4cd98f768936
- **GDRFA Dubai — business entry visa for partner/investor:** https://www.gdrfad.gov.ae/en/services/2b2f69af-408c-11ed-4fe5-0050569629e8
- **Ministry of Economy & Tourism — free-zone company registrars:** https://www.moet.gov.ae/en/company-registrars-in-free-zones
- **Creative City — published package examples:** https://creativecity.gov.ae/company-set-up/

12. Practical recommendation

Before selecting a route, write down (1) exact business activity, (2) where your customers will be, (3) whether you need a UAE residence visa and how many, (4) whether you need physical office/warehouse space, (5) shareholder count and whether any shareholder is a company, and (6) first-year and renewal budget. Send the same checklist to two or three relevant authorities and compare their written, itemised quotes. For any quote, ask whether it includes VAT, licence/registration, facility, immigration establishment card, visa allocation, entry permit, status change, medical, Emirates ID, insurance, deposits and renewal.